A SERMON FOR THE PULPIT

What the Room Called Waste

A sermon on Mary of Bethany

THE BIG IDEA

Love that has understood the cross stops calculating what devotion is worth.

PRIMARY TEXT	John 12:1–8
ALSO READ	Mark 14:3–9; Matthew 26:6–13; Luke 10:38–42; John 11:1–44
TIME	50–60 minutes, including a 3–5 minute response.

Scripture quotations are ESV. Swap to your pulpit translation freely.

A COMPLETE MANUSCRIPT FOR THE PULPIT

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Introduction: The smell in the room

If you had walked into that house, you would have smelled it before you understood it.

It was the smell of nard — spikenard, the Gospels call it — a perfume imported from the mountains of northern India, carried overland through many hands, sealed in an alabaster flask. It was expensive enough that a person could live on its value for a year. It was strong enough that it filled the house.

And it was everywhere.

On his head. On his feet. In her hair. In the air. In the clothes of everyone who sat at that table. The room could not ignore what had happened. The room could not pretend it had not seen. The smell was the witness.

That is the first thing I want you to notice about this story. It is not a quiet story. It is not a private story. It is a story that fills a room.

Six days before Passover, Jesus was in Bethany, two miles from Jerusalem. He was a wanted man. The chief priests and the Pharisees had given orders that anyone who knew where he was should report it so they could arrest him (John 11:57). The city was filling with pilgrims. The lambs were being brought in. The air was thick with expectation.

Passover was the feast of deliverance. Every family remembered the night the blood on the doorpost saved them from death. Every lamb in the city was a reminder. The chief priests knew what Jesus could do to a crowd. And Jesus knew what was waiting for him in Jerusalem.

And Jesus was at a dinner table.

The house belonged to a man named Simon, whom the Gospels call Simon the leper (Mark 14:3; Matthew 26:6). We do not know whether he was still a leper or had been healed. But the name stuck. Maybe it was the only name people had for him. Maybe it was a way of remembering what Jesus had done.

Either way, Simon's table was a statement. A man known as a leper did not host dinner parties. Lepers were kept at a distance. They were the ones you crossed the street to avoid. And now Simon was hosting the most wanted man in Judea, with a resurrected man at the table and a woman who was about to break a year's wages over the guest of honor. The room was not respectable. It was redeemed.

Lazarus was at the table too. Four days dead. Wrapped. Buried. And then called out of the tomb by name. He was not a memory. He was a man with an appetite. He was sitting there, alive.

Martha was serving. Of course she was. That is what Martha did. She had once complained that Mary was not helping. Jesus had told her that Mary had chosen the good portion. Martha had not stopped serving, but she had learned something about the one she served. Now she served the risen brother and the one who raised him.

And Mary was there.

The text does not tell us that she said a word. It tells us what she did.

She stood up in the middle of the dinner, carrying the most expensive thing in the house.

The room went quiet. Everyone knew what that jar was worth. Everyone knew what it was for. It was not the kind of thing you opened at dinner. It was the kind of thing you saved for a wedding, a burial, a once-in-a-lifetime moment. And she was carrying it toward Jesus.

Movement 1: The room full of evidence

Before we watch what she does, I want you to look around the room.

This is not a room of strangers. This is a room of evidence.

Simon is there. A man whose skin had once told a story of exclusion. Lepers lived outside the camp. They kept their distance. They called out, "Unclean." Whatever Simon's body looked like now, his name was a monument to the fact that Jesus had touched him.

Lazarus is there. A man who had been dead long enough for the mourners to be sure. Four days. The text is careful about it. Martha had objected: "Lord, by this time there is a bad odor, for he has been dead four days" (John 11:39). She was not being rude. She was being honest. And Jesus had called him out anyway.

Lazarus is not a symbol at that table. He is a man eating dinner. He is the evidence with an appetite.

And his presence was dangerous. John tells us that the chief priests made plans to put Lazarus to death as well, because on account of him many of the Jews were believing in Jesus (John 12:10–11). The evidence was so strong that they wanted to kill it. That is what evidence does when it threatens the wrong people. It gets managed. It gets explained. It gets buried. But Lazarus was already buried once, and it did not take.

Martha is there. Serving. The last time we saw her in John's Gospel, she was the one who went out to meet Jesus while Mary stayed in the house. She said, "Lord, if you had been here, my brother would not have died" (John 11:21). She believed in the resurrection at the last day. Jesus told her, "I am the resurrection and the life" (John 11:25). And then he went to the tomb and wept.

Martha has seen a lot. She is not the same woman who complained about the dishes.

And Jesus is there. The wanted man. The one the authorities are looking for. He knows what is waiting for him in Jerusalem. He has told his disciples three times. They did not want to hear it. He came to Bethany anyway.

That is worth pausing over. He did not have to come. He could have stayed in the wilderness, stayed in the villages, stayed out of reach. But he came to the table. He came to the people he loved. Love moves toward the danger.

And this was a celebration. John says they made him a supper (John 12:2). It may have been a thank-you dinner for Lazarus. It may have been a family reunion. The food was on the table, the wine was poured, the dead man was laughing. It was the best party in Bethany. It was also the last one.

The room is full of evidence that Jesus is who he says he is.

And yet.

And yet the room is about to miss the point.

That is the strange thing about evidence. It does not automatically produce faith. You can see a dead man breathing and still calculate. You can watch a leper embrace his family and still keep your distance. You can sit at the table with the resurrection and the life and still ask, "What is this costing us?"

The Gospels tell us that after Jesus raised Lazarus, many of the Jews believed in him. But some of them went to the Pharisees and told them what Jesus had done (John 11:45–46). Same miracle. Same evidence. Different responses.

Evidence is not the same thing as love.

The disciples had more evidence than anyone. They had watched him heal the sick, feed the crowd, calm the sea, raise the dead. They had heard his voice on the mountain. And when the pressure came, they ran. Evidence can fill a room and still leave the heart sealed. That is why

Jesus would later say, "Blessed are those who have not seen and yet have believed" (John 20:29).

That is why you can grow up in a church and still have a sealed jar. That is why you can know all the stories and still do the math. That is why you can be in the room when the dead man eats dinner and still wonder whether devotion is worth the cost.

The room was full of evidence. And the room was about to call love a waste.

Movement 2: The woman who had been listening

So who is this woman?

Her name is Mary. She is the sister of Martha and Lazarus. She lives in Bethany. And she is not the woman in Luke 7 who washed Jesus' feet with her tears. That was a different woman, in a different house, at a different moment. She is not Mary Magdalene either. An old confusion tied the two Marys together, but the Gospels do not. Mary of Bethany is her own person, with her own story.

And her story is told in three scenes.

The first scene is in Luke 10. Jesus comes to the village, and Martha opens her home. Martha is busy with the preparations. Mary sits at Jesus' feet and listens to his teaching.

In that world, sitting at a rabbi's feet was the posture of a disciple. Rabbis did not formally take women as students. Mary sat there anyway. She took the place of a learner. She gave Jesus her attention in a way that was not expected, not socially safe, and not particularly useful for getting dinner on the table.

Martha protests. "Lord, do you not care that my sister has left me to serve alone? Tell her then to help me" (Luke 10:40).

And Jesus answers, "Martha, Martha, you are anxious and troubled about many things, but one thing is necessary. Mary has chosen the good portion, which will not be taken away from her" (Luke 10:41–42).

That is the first time Jesus defends Mary.

The second scene is in John 11. Lazarus is dead. Jesus has not come when they sent for him. Martha goes out to meet him. Mary stays in the house. Then Jesus asks for her, and she comes.

She falls at his feet. And she says the rawest sentence in the story: "Lord, if you had been here, my brother would not have died" (John 11:32).

She does not say it to a stranger. She says it to the one she has been listening to. She says it at his feet, where she has sat before. She says it with tears.

And Jesus does not explain. He does not defend himself. He does not tell her to be more theological. He weeps (John 11:35).

The man who is about to call her brother out of the grave stands at the grave and cries with her first.

That is the second thing Mary knows about Jesus. He is not distant. He is not embarrassed by grief. He is not in a hurry to fix it. He enters it.

Then he raises Lazarus.

The third scene is the dinner at Simon's house.

Do you see the shape of her life? She sat at his feet. She wept at his feet. Now she kneels at his feet again.

She has been paying attention.

Look at where she is in every scene. At his feet, listening. At his feet, weeping. At his feet, anointing. The same posture, three times. She is not a woman who has a religious experience and then goes back to her life. She is a woman who has learned to stay. The feet of Jesus are the geography of her discipleship.

That is where the jar comes from.

We tend to read this story as a sudden act of emotion. A woman gets carried away. A room gets embarrassed. A generous gesture gets defended. But the text will not let us read it that way. Mary's act is not a spike of feeling. It is the fruit of a life.

She had listened when Jesus said he was going to die.

She had heard him speak of his death. She had watched him raise her brother and then watched him walk toward Jerusalem anyway. She had put the pieces together.

And the room had not. Peter had rebuked him for saying it. The disciples had argued about who would be greatest. They had asked for seats at his right and left. They fell asleep in the garden.

They ran. They had heard the words, but they had not let the words into the room where their future lived. Mary had. That is the difference between hearing and listening.

The room was waiting for a crown. Mary had been listening to a burial.

That is why she brings the jar. It is not a random luxury. It is a burial perfume. It is the kind of thing you use on a body. And she brings it to a dinner party.

She is not decorating the evening. She is preparing a funeral.

Six days before Passover. The city was preparing for Passover. Every household would soon choose its lamb, looking for a blemish. Mary was not at the temple. She was at a table. But she was doing the same thing. She was anointing the Lamb. She was saying, without knowing all of it, "This is the one."

The text does not tell us how much she understood. It does not tell us whether she could have explained it. But Jesus interprets her act as a burial anointing, and he receives it as one. Whatever she knew, she knew enough to act.

She had been listening. That is the first thing the room had stopped doing.

Movement 3: The jar that could not be saved

Now watch what she does.

She brings an alabaster flask of pure nard. Mark tells us it was very costly (Mark 14:3). John tells us it was worth three hundred denarii (John 12:5). A denarius was a day's wage for a common laborer. Three hundred of them is three hundred days of work. Close to a year. It was not pocket money. It was a year of someone's life, sealed in stone.

We are not told where Mary got it. It may have been a family inheritance. It may have been a dowry. It may have been saved for years. The text does not say, and we should not pretend to know. But we know what it was worth: a year of work, a year of security, a year of options. And she broke it.

Nard came from the mountains of northern India. It was carried overland, through many hands, across many borders. It was rare even for the wealthy. This was not the cheap stuff. This was the real thing.

And it was sealed.

That detail matters. A sealed alabaster flask could have been opened slowly. You could have poured out a little and kept the rest. You could save some for another day. You could make it last.

Mary did not do that.

Mark says she broke the flask (Mark 14:3). She did not unseal it. She broke it. That meant it could not be resealed. It could not be saved in part. It was finished. The whole thing was going out.

She poured it on his head, as Mark and Matthew record. She poured it on his feet, as John adds. She wiped his feet with her hair. The whole body. The whole jar. The whole year.

And the house was filled with the fragrance of the perfume (John 12:3).

There is no way to do this quietly. There is no way to break a jar of nard in a room full of people and have no one notice. The smell goes everywhere. It gets into the cushions. It gets into the clothes. It gets into the hair of the people who were standing too close. It is still there when the dinner is over.

Worship is like that. It is not a private transaction between you and God that no one else can see. It fills the room. It changes the smell of the house.

Now think about what she is doing with her hair.

In that culture, a woman letting down her hair in a room full of men who were not her family was a scandal. It was the kind of thing that would make people look away. It was the posture of a woman with no reputation left to protect.

And she uses her hair as a towel.

The most expensive thing she owns, poured out in the posture of the lowest servant. That is the shape of worship. Cost and humility together. The jar and the towel. The year's wages and the hair.

She is not trying to be impressive. She is trying to be close.

There is a difference between giving God a portion and giving him the container. A portion is manageable. A portion can be budgeted. A portion leaves you with something in reserve. The container is different. The container says, "I am not keeping my options open." That is what makes the room uncomfortable. It is not the money. It is the surrender. The money is just the visible part.

And she is not giving him a portion. She is giving him the container. She is not saying, "Here is something for you." She is saying, "Here is everything, and I am not asking for it back."

That is the thing the room cannot understand.

Let me say what this is not.

This is not a sermon that says, "Sell your house." This is not a stewardship campaign disguised as an exposition. Mary's act is unique in its moment. Jesus says she did what she could, and he connects it to his burial. You are not called to reproduce the exact gesture. You are called to understand the love that produced it.

The application is not "sell everything." The application is "stop calculating what devotion is worth."

But do not soften the cost either.

David said, "I will not offer burnt offerings to the LORD my God that cost me nothing" (2 Samuel 24:24). Worship that costs nothing is not worship. It is a tip. It is a polite acknowledgment that leaves the jar sealed.

The cost is not always money. The widow with two mites gave more than the rich men with their gold, because she gave what she had (Mark 12:41–44). Jesus measures the cost in what it means to the giver, not in the number on the jar. But there is always a cost. There is always something that has to be broken.

The jar is whatever you have sealed because you are afraid of what will happen if it opens.

It may be money. It may be time. It may be a reputation you have spent years building. It may be a plan for your future that you are not willing to hand over. It may be a grievance you have kept in a safe place because forgiving it would leave you with nothing to hold against the person who hurt you. It may be the right to be seen as sensible, reasonable, in control.

You can carry a sealed jar for a long time. It looks like wisdom. It looks like stewardship. It looks like responsibility. It looks like you are the only adult in the room.

But a sealed jar is still a sealed jar. It cannot fill the house.

Mary broke hers. And the room has never forgotten the smell.

Movement 4: The objection that sounds spiritual

And someone objected.

"Why was this ointment not sold for three hundred denarii and given to the poor?" (John 12:5).

It is a good question. That is what makes it dangerous.

The most dangerous objections to devotion are not obviously wicked. They are reasonable. They are moral. They sound like they are on the side of the poor, the vulnerable, the responsible use of resources. They sound like something Jesus would say.

And sometimes they are sincere.

The Bible is not indifferent to the poor. Deuteronomy 15:11 says, "For there will never cease to be poor in the land. Therefore I command you, 'You shall open wide your hand to your brother, to the needy and to the poor, in your land.'"

That is the verse Jesus is quoting.

When Jesus says, "You always have the poor with you, but you will not always have me" (John 12:8), he is not cancelling the command to care for the poor. He is quoting a verse that commands generosity. He is saying, "You will always have opportunities to give to the poor. You will not always have this moment with me."

The poor are not a distraction from worship. Care for the poor is one of the ways worship becomes visible. A church that sings about the worth of Jesus and ignores the poor has not understood the song. A church that cares for the poor but never worships the one who made them has not understood the poor.

The two are not enemies. The room was wrong to use the poor as a reason to stop worship. We are wrong when we use worship as a reason to stop caring for the poor. The gospel does not ask us to choose between the altar and the alley. It asks us to carry the altar into the alley.

The objection can be sincere. But it can also become a hiding place.

John tells us who said it: Judas Iscariot, the one who would betray him. And John tells us why: not because he cared for the poor, but because he was a thief. He kept the money bag and used to steal what was put into it (John 12:6).

He knew the number exactly.

That is the detail that should make us shiver. He had done the math before she broke the jar. He knew what it was worth. He had already calculated what he could do with it. And when she poured it out, he did not see worship. He saw a loss.

The man who would sell Jesus for thirty pieces of silver is the man doing the math on Mary's jar.

Three hundred denarii. Thirty pieces of silver. A year's wages. A slave's price. A woman's love. A disciple's betrayal. The jar and the bag.

The contrast is the point.

Three hundred denarii was roughly a year's wages. Thirty pieces of silver was the price of a slave (Exodus 21:32). Matthew tells us that is what Judas asked for (Matthew 26:15). He watched a woman give a year of her life in love, and then he sold Jesus for the price of a servant. The man who called the jar a waste had already put a price on the one she was anointing. He was not wrong about the arithmetic. He was wrong about the worth.

But do not turn Judas into a cartoon. The question he asks is a real question. Many sincere people ask it. Many of us have asked it. The issue is not that the question is wicked. The issue is that the question can be a way of keeping control.

If I am the one doing the math, I am the one deciding what is worth it. If I am the one auditing her devotion, I do not have to look at my own sealed jar. If I can make her generosity sound irresponsible, I can feel responsible for doing nothing.

That is the deeper question in the room. Not "Was the jar expensive?" but "What is Jesus worth?"

Mary's answer is a year's wages, broken open, with no possibility of getting it back.

The room's answer is, "What a waste."

Jesus' answer is, "She has done a beautiful thing to me" (Mark 14:6).

The room called it waste. Jesus called it beautiful.

The same act. Two judgments. One of them is true.

The room's judgment was reasonable. That is what makes it so dangerous. It was not the judgment of people who hated Jesus. It was the judgment of people who were close enough to see the jar and close enough to know the poor. It sounded like stewardship. It sounded like compassion. It sounded like the kind of thing a serious disciple would say. And it was still

wrong, because it was measuring devotion by what it could have done instead of by who it was for.

And notice: the objection did not stop her. The text does not tell us that Mary argued. She did not defend herself. She did not explain the economics. She did not say, "Actually, if you factor in the value of what Jesus has done for my brother..." She let Jesus answer for her.

That is a picture of the gospel. We do not stand before God on the basis of our own defense. We stand on the basis of his. He defends the ones who love him. He speaks for the ones the room has written off.

There is a moment in this story when the room is looking at Mary, and Mary is looking at Jesus. And Jesus is looking at the room and saying, "Leave her alone."

If you have ever been misunderstood for loving him, you know how precious that sentence is.

If you have ever been the one doing the misunderstanding, you know how much you need it too.

The question is not whether you have asked, "Why this waste?" The question is whether you will let him answer it.

Movement 5: The burial she understood

Jesus says something that changes everything.

"She has anointed my body beforehand for burial" (Mark 14:8).

He interprets her act. He tells the room what she has done. She has not just anointed a living teacher. She has anointed a body for burial. She has done ahead of time what the women will try to do on Sunday morning and will not be able to do because the tomb is empty.

She has prepared him for a funeral.

The room is at a dinner party. She is at a burial. The smell of nard is the smell of death. The celebration is also a preparation. The joy is real, but it is not the whole story. Six days from now, the same city will shout, "Crucify him" (Mark 15:13–14). The same streets will be full of the same people. The same Jesus will be on a cross.

Mary is the only one in the room who acts like this is a burial.

And Jesus receives it.

He does not say, "That is a bit much." He does not say, "Save it for later." He does not say, "You are being dramatic." He says, "Leave her alone. She has done a beautiful thing to me."

He receives the anointing because he is going to the cross.

That is the heart of the story. The cross is not an accident that happens to Jesus. It is not a plan that falls apart and gets rescued. It is the plan. He is the Lamb. He is the Passover. He is the one who will be broken and poured out.

Six days before Passover, a woman anointed the Lamb.

Passover was not a random date. It was the feast of deliverance. The lamb had to be without blemish. It had to be examined. It had to be killed and eaten, and its blood had to be on the door. Jesus is the Lamb who would be examined by the priests and the governor, condemned by the crowd, and killed outside the gate. And before any of that happened, a woman anointed him for burial. The passion begins at a dinner table.

The cross is where the question "What is Jesus worth?" gets its answer.

The room looked at a year's wages poured out and called it waste. The world looked at the Son of God on a cross and called it a failure. A dead teacher. A lost cause. A movement that ended the way all movements end.

But the cross is not waste. The cross is love without calculation.

"He who did not spare his own Son but gave him up for us all, how will he not also with him graciously give us all things?" (Romans 8:32).

"While we were still sinners, Christ died for us" (Romans 5:8).

That is the shape of the gospel. God did not wait for us to be worth it. He did not do the math and decide we were a good investment. He loved us while we were a loss. He gave everything when everything in us said "not worth it."

At the cross, the jar is broken open.

The Father did not send the Son reluctantly. The Son did not go unwillingly. Jesus said, "No one takes my life from me, but I lay it down of my own accord" (John 10:18). The cross is not just a payment. It is an act of devotion. It is the Son loving the Father and loving us enough to give everything. If you want to know what love without calculation looks like, do not look at the room. Look at the cross.

If you want to know what God thinks devotion is worth, look at the cross. He did not hold back a portion. He did not keep the flask sealed for another day. He gave his Son. The Father gave the Son. The Son gave himself. And the Spirit carries the fragrance of that gift into every room where the gospel is preached.

And the tomb was empty.

On Sunday morning, some women went to the tomb carrying spices, expecting to anoint a body. They did not find one. They found an angel, a rolled-away stone, and a message: "He is not here; he has risen" (Matthew 28:6). Mary's anointing pointed to the burial that was coming. The women who came after the Sabbath found that the burial was not the end. They came to prepare a corpse, and they were sent to proclaim a King.

That is the part the room did not see coming. Mary prepared him for a burial he would not stay in. She anointed a body that would not stay dead. The fragrance of that burial did not stay in the grave. It filled the house, and then it filled the world.

Jesus says, "Truly, I say to you, wherever the gospel is proclaimed in the whole world, what she has done will also be told in memory of her" (Mark 14:9).

He made her a part of the gospel story.

Not because she was famous. Not because she was important. Not because she had a platform. Because she loved him in a way that the room could not understand, and he would not let it be forgotten.

She is the woman Jesus said we would never forget.

And here we are, two thousand years later, still talking about her. Still smelling the nard. Still hearing the jar break. Still watching the room do its math and the Lord defend her.

The gospel is still being proclaimed. And she is still being remembered.

The question is whether we will join her.

Application: What do you do with the jar?

So what do you do now?

You have heard the story. You have seen the room. You have seen the jar. You have heard the objection. You have heard the Lord's verdict.

What do you do with the jar?

Let me give you four things. Not four steps to earn anything. Four responses to what you have seen.

1. Name the jar

Do not be vague about this. Vague devotion is easy. Name the thing you are holding shut.

It may be money. It may be a specific amount, a specific account, a specific plan for what you are going to do with it. It may be time — the hours you protect, the margin you will not give up, the rest you feel you have earned. It may be a relationship you are keeping at arm's length because getting close would cost you something. It may be a reputation. It may be a grievance. It may be a future you have already written and are afraid to hand over.

The jar is the thing you have sealed because you are afraid of what will happen if it breaks.

Name it. Not to me. Not to the person next to you. To God. In your own heart. Say it plainly. "This is the jar."

You cannot break what you will not name.

2. Do one uncalculated act

Mary did what the moment required. She did not wait for a committee. She did not run a cost-benefit analysis. She did not ask permission. She saw the opportunity to love him, and she took it.

This week, do one thing for Jesus that cannot be justified on a spreadsheet.

Not a grand gesture. A true one. A forgiveness that costs you the right to be right. A generosity that no one will applaud. A Sunday spent serving instead of being served. A conversation you have been avoiding. A gift that is too large for your reputation and too small for a receipt. A prayer that is honest enough to be embarrassing.

Do something that only makes sense if Jesus is who he says he is.

Maybe it is a check you have been afraid to write. Maybe it is a Saturday you have been guarding. Maybe it is a conversation with someone who hurt you, where you give up the right to make them pay. Maybe it is a commitment to a ministry that will never put your name on a plaque. Maybe it is simply getting up earlier to pray when no one is watching and no one will thank you. Do one thing. Not ten. One.

That is what worship is. It is not the safe part of your life. It is the part that looks a little like waste to the room.

3. Stop auditing someone else's devotion

The room did the math on Mary. We do it in churches. We do it in families. We do it in our own heads.

"Why is she so emotional?" "Why does he give that much?" "Why do they spend money on that?" "Why is that church doing it that way?" "Why is that person so serious about this?"

Sometimes the question is sincere. Sometimes it is a way of protecting our own sealed jar.

You are not the auditor of another person's love.

You do not know what they have seen. You do not know what it cost them. You do not know what Jesus has done for them in the dark. You do not know what they are pouring out.

Stop doing the math on someone else's devotion. Do the math on your own. And then stop doing the math altogether and look at him.

You do not have to understand why someone else is weeping, giving, staying, or going. You do not have to approve of every choice. You do have to stop using your disapproval as a way of avoiding your own surrender. The room had a hundred reasons to critique Mary's gift. None of them required the room to open its own hands.

4. Make room for grief

Mary's act came after the tomb.

She had stood at her brother's grave. She had said, "If you had been here." She had watched Jesus weep. And then she had watched him call Lazarus out. Her devotion grew in the place where she stopped pretending death was not real.

Some of you are carrying grief you have not named. The room wants you to move on. The room wants you to be fine. The room wants you to keep your jar sealed and your face composed.

Jesus wept. There is room at his feet for your tears.

You do not have to have it all together to worship him. You do not have to understand the burial to anoint him. You do not have to be strong. You have to be there.

Mary was there. That is where it started.

The invitation

You cannot manufacture this kind of love.

You can try. You can read the books. You can adopt the disciplines. You can serve harder. You can give more. You can sing louder. But if you are still doing the math, none of it will break the jar.

This kind of love comes from being with him.

You cannot break the jar by clenching your teeth. You break it by seeing him. You break it by sitting at his feet until the calculations lose their grip. You break it by standing at the tomb long enough to hear him weep. You break it by watching him go to the cross and understanding, for the first time, that he did not consider you a waste.

Mary sat at his feet. She stood at the tomb. She listened when the others did not. She saw him weep. She watched him raise the dead. She put her life next to his, and her heart caught up.

That is the invitation this morning. Not "try harder." Not "be more generous." Not "stop being so selfish." The invitation is "come closer."

Come closer to the one who was anointed for burial. Come closer to the one who was broken and poured out. Come closer to the one who did not calculate. Come closer to the one who loved you while you were still a loss.

And if you have been the one doing the math in the room — if you have been using spiritual language to protect yourself, standing close to Jesus with a sealed jar and a full bag — the invitation is for you too.

The one who defended Mary is the one who went to the cross for the people who called it waste.

He did not come for the people who got it right. He came for the room that got it wrong.

You can come back. You can open your hands. You can let him answer for you. You can stay.

Response

In a moment, I am going to ask you to do something simple.

Not to come forward. Not to stand. Not to sing. Just to be quiet.

In the quiet, name the jar. You do not have to say it out loud. You do not have to tell anyone. Say it to God. "This is what I have been holding shut. This is what I am afraid to break."

Then ask him one question: "What would it look like to love you without calculating?"

Do not answer it too quickly. Let it sit. Let the smell of the room fill your imagination. Let the jar break again.

And then, if you can, tell him one thing you will do this week. One uncalculated act. One small, true, costly thing. Not so you can be praised. Not so you can be seen. Because he is worth it.

Let us pray.

Lord Jesus, you saw what Mary understood, and you defended her when the room called it waste. Give us the courage to love you without calculating. Give us the honesty to admit the places where we are still holding the jar shut. Teach us to care for the poor without using them as an excuse to avoid you. Teach us to worship without using worship as an excuse to avoid the poor. And when we do not understand what you are doing, give us the grace to stay at your feet.

Break what needs to be broken. Fill this house with the fragrance of your worth. And make us, like her, a story that tells the world what you are like.

We ask this in your name. Amen.

Closing

The room called it waste.

Jesus called it beautiful.

She broke the jar. He emptied the tomb. And he made sure she would never be forgotten.

Wherever the gospel is preached, she is still here.

May the same be said of us.

Evidence note for the preacher

- The anointing at Bethany is told in Mark 14:3–9, Matthew 26:6–13, and John 12:1–8. Luke 10:38–42 gives the earlier scene of Mary at Jesus' feet; John 11 gives the raising of Lazarus. Luke 7 is a different anointing, by a different woman, and should not be conflated with this scene.

- The value of the nard is given as three hundred denarii in John 12:5; Mark 14:5 says it was worth more than three hundred. A denarius was a day's wage for a common laborer; three hundred denarii is roughly a year's wages.
- Jesus predicted his death in Mark 8:31, 9:31, and 10:33–34. The sermon does not claim Mary was present for those private conversations; it claims that she had heard him speak of his death and had put the pieces together from what she had seen and heard.
- Mark 14:3 says the flask was broken; John 12:3 says she poured it on his feet and wiped them with her hair. Mark and Matthew focus on the head. The accounts are complementary, not contradictory.
- Judas' motive is stated in John 12:6: he kept the money bag and stole from it. Matthew 26:8 says the disciples were indignant; Mark 14:4 says some were. John names the source of the objection.
- Jesus quotes Deuteronomy 15:11 when he says, "You always have the poor with you." The verse commands generosity to the poor; it is not a dismissal of the poor.
- The thirty pieces of silver are in Matthew 26:15. Exodus 21:32 gives thirty shekels as the compensation for a slave; Zechariah 11:12–13 is the prophetic background Matthew echoes.
- The tomb was sealed with a stone (Matthew 27:66). The resurrection is attested in all four Gospels.
- The "aroma of Christ" image in 2 Corinthians 2:14–16 is a useful companion text for the fragrance motif, but it is not required for the sermon.